CHOCOLATE HAZELNUT TART

MAKES	ACTIVE TIME	TOTAL TIME	OVEN
1 tart at 23 cm or 6 to 8 tartlets at 10 cm, 8 to 12 servings	**25 min**	**about 1 h 30 min including cooling, not counting the shell**	**325F/160C for 7 to 9 min**

INGREDIENTS

1 batch	Sweet tart dough, baked and cooled
170 g	Bittersweet chocolate, coarsely chopped
115 g	Unsalted butter
60 ml	Brandy, optional
70 g	Sugar, for the butter mixture
65 g	Sugar, for the eggs
3	Eggs, large
1/2 tsp	Orange zest
1/8 tsp	Salt
140 g	Hazelnuts, lightly toasted and rubbed free of their skins

METHOD

1. Make the sweet tart dough, line a 23 cm tart pan or six to eight 10 cm tartlet pans, bake the shells through and cool them. See the dough.
2. Heat the oven to 325F/160C and have the cooled shell ready.
3. Tip the chopped chocolate into a heatproof mixing bowl.
4. Put the butter, the brandy if you are using it, and 70 g of the sugar in a saucepan. Stir over medium-low heat until the butter has melted and the sugar is fully dissolved.
5. Pour the hot butter mixture onto the chocolate and stir it with a rubber spatula to a smooth melt.
6. Put the remaining 65 g of sugar in a large bowl with the eggs, the orange zest and the salt.
7. Whip on medium for about 3 minutes, machine or arm either way. You are after a pale, aerated mass that falls off the lifted whisk in a thick ribbon.
8. Whisk a third of the beaten eggs into the chocolate to loosen it, then fold the remainder in with a rubber spatula.
9. Pour the filling into the shell and level the top with an offset spatula.
10. Lay the hazelnuts over the surface in an even layer.
11. Bake 7 to 9 minutes, until the filling has lost some of its shine.
12. Let the tart cool all the way down on a rack, then serve it at room temperature.

NOTES

Sugar is 135 g in total, split two ways. 70 g dissolves into the warm butter and brandy, the other 65 g is beaten with the eggs.
Beating the eggs to a ribbon is what keeps the filling light under 170 g of chocolate.
The filling can be made ahead and refrigerated. Spoon it into the shell cold, smooth the top and bake as written.
Variations on the same filling: equal weights of coffee and walnuts in place of the brandy and hazelnuts, or prunes soaked in Armagnac laid into the shell before the filling goes in, with the brandy and nuts left out.
Keeps well wrapped in the refrigerator up to 5 days.

DOUGH

Sweet Tart Dough

Makes: 4 tart shells, 23 cm, or 12 tartlet shells at 10 cm / Active Time: 15 min / Rest: 2 h chilled minimum or overnight, then 15 min once lined / Total Time: about 2 h 45 min / Oven: 325F / 160C, 7 to 10 min partially baked, 5 min longer for fully baked

INGREDIENTS

255 g	Unsalted butter, at room temperature
200 g	Sugar
1/4 tsp	Salt
2	Eggs, large, at room temperature
500 g	All-purpose flour
1	Egg, large, for the wash
a pinch	Salt, for the wash

METHOD

1. Paddle the butter, sugar and salt together in a stand mixer on medium until the mixture is smooth.
2. Beat in one egg, then the second, and keep going until it is smooth again.
3. Stop the mixer and scrape the bowl down with a rubber spatula.
4. Tip in all the flour at once and run the mixer on low only until it disappears into the dough.
5. On a lightly floured bench, divide the dough into four equal balls and flatten each into a disk 12 mm thick. Wrap tightly and chill at least 2 hours, or overnight.
6. To line a pan, roll a disk out to 3 mm on a lightly floured surface, working from the middle outward in every direction. Lift the sheet and swing it a quarter turn every few passes, dusting underneath when it starts to grab, and move fast so it does not warm up.
7. Cut a circle 5 cm wider than the pan.
8. While the dough is still cool, lay the circle in the pan, settle it into the bottom and up the sides, and press it home gently. Never pull it to fit, because stretched sides shrink back during the bake.
9. If the dough has gone too soft to handle, give it a few minutes in the fridge before you transfer it.
10. Patch any tear with a scrap of dough, pressing firmly so it sticks. With a sharp knife, trim the edge flush with the rim of the pan.
11. Put the lined shell in the fridge or freezer until firm, about 15 minutes.
12. For tartlets, roll the dough the same way, cut circles to suit your pans and line them. Freeze what is left over, scraps included.
13. Heat the oven to 325F. Prick the base of the shell all over with fork tines or a knife tip, tiny holes about 5 cm apart.
14. Bake a large shell 7 to 10 minutes for partially baked, or tartlet shells 5 to 7 minutes. It should look dry and matte with only a little color. Check during the bake and turn the pans if one side is coloring faster.
15. To seal the shell with egg wash, beat the egg with a pinch of salt. A minute or two short of the color you want, pull the shell out, brush the base and sides thinly, then return it until the color arrives and the coating has set.
16. For a fully baked shell, carry on as above but give it about 5 minutes more, to golden brown.
17. Cool the shells completely on wire racks.

NOTES

> Egg wash brushed on the inside of a partially baked shell seals the pastry and keeps the crust crisp longer under a wet filling.
> An easy dough to work. It rolls very thin, holds its shape instead of slumping down the pan, and takes being re-rolled several times without going tough.
> To get eggs to room temperature fast, sit them in a bowl under running lukewarm water for about 5 minutes.
> Leftover dough bakes off as a plain cookie dough.

DATE ___ / ___ / ___ RATING ___ / 5 OVEN ADJ _____

NOTES _____

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